

Trump backs Epstein files vote

President appears to shift stance as support builds in House for measure

BY MARIANA ALFARO

Ahead of a closely watched vote this week, key lawmakers say support is building in the House for a measure that would require the government to release all of the information the Justice Department has related to its investigation into convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

And after resisting backing such a measure for weeks, President Donald Trump said late Sunday on social media that he believes “House Republicans should vote to release the Epstein files, because we have nothing to hide.”

Before Trump’s post, Rep. Thomas Massie (R-Kentucky), who introduced the petition with Rep. Ro Khanna (D-California), suggested that “100 or more” House Republicans could vote in favor of releasing the Epstein files this week despite opposition from Trump.

“We could have a deluge of Republicans,” he said Sunday morning on ABC’s “This Week.” “I’m hoping to get a veto-proof majority on this legislation when it comes up for a vote.” Khanna had a more conservative estimate of 40 or more Republican colleagues backing the vote.

House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) did not give an estimate, but he acknowledged Sunday that there will be “lots of votes” for the bill when it comes to the floor this week.

SEE EPSTEIN ON A6



KEVIN FRAYER/GETTY IMAGES

DF-5C missiles are debuted in Beijing on Sept. 3 at a military parade marking the anniversary of the end of World War II.

In the desert, a Chinese nuclear test site grows

Quiet expansion comes as Trump revives Cold War-era tensions

BY CATE CADELL

President Donald Trump’s announcement this month that the United States would restart nuclear weapons testing on an “equal basis” with other nations — alluding to unverified claims that Moscow and Beijing are conducting secret tests and sug-

gesting the U.S. will revive programs abandoned in the early 1990s — has sowed confusion among the world’s nuclear powers and revived echoes of the Cold War arms race.

While Moscow was quick to call for proposals on restarting its own nuclear weapons testing program, Beijing has stayed largely silent. But in the remote deserts of western China, the People’s Liberation Army has long been bracing for just this kind of threat.

In far-western Xinjiang, satellite imagery and expert analysis show that China is rapidly

expanding a historic nuclear test site, where it conducted its first atomic bomb test in 1964. The country’s military has quietly carved new tunnels, hollowed out explosive chambers and built support facilities that researchers say suggest preparations for nuclear testing.

Though China’s nuclear program remains years behind those of Russia and the United States, analysts say it is precisely that disparity that may be driving the apparent expansion of its testing facilities.

“Given the fact that China has conducted the smallest number

of nuclear tests, it has much less empirical data. ... China may have a need to conduct more experiments at either the subcritical level or through very low-yield supercritical testing to learn more about nuclear weapons,” said Tong Zhao, a senior fellow at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace.

Behind China’s drive to expand its nuclear arsenal — currently the world’s third largest — is a broader strategy under President Xi Jinping to modernize the country’s military by

SEE CHINA ON A14

GOP sifts for remedy on ACA

MENU OF OPTIONS ON HEALTH SUBSIDIES

Parties’ dueling votes loom in mid-December

BY DAN DIAMOND AND PAIGE WINFIELD CUNNINGHAM

President Donald Trump has again promised a “far better and far less expensive” alternative to the Affordable Care Act, and Republicans are rushing — again — to deliver one.

For weeks throughout the longest government shutdown in history, Trump avoided negotiating with Democrats on the health care concerns fueling their standoff. Now lawmakers on both sides of the aisle are speeding toward a self-imposed deadline of mid-December to hold dueling health care votes.

Democrats maintain that the simplest and most popular option is to extend ACA subsidies set to expire next month. Analysts say millions of people — many in states that supported Trump — will forgo health insurance if the program ends. The president’s own pollster has warned that not extending the subsidies would pose a major political risk for the GOP in the midterms.

But rather than sign on to Democrats’ proposal, the president has argued that billions of dollars in ACA subsidy money should be redirected away from health insurers and toward the

SEE HEALTH CARE ON A6

CEO takes flak from his liberal hometown

Billionaire faces backlash after initially endorsing a Guard surge in Bay Area

BY LISA BONOS

SAN FRANCISCO — While tech moguls such as Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg sat center stage at President Donald Trump’s January inauguration, Marc Benioff, CEO of cloud software company Salesforce, was 4,000 miles away at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland.

Benioff, an influential philanthropist and political voice in San Francisco, appeared set on making clear he wasn’t moving toward Trump. He said at one Davos event that the new administration would not change his or Salesforce’s core values, which include equality and sustainability. “Presidents change. Administrations change. We don’t change,” Benioff said in an onstage interview at a slick event space hosted by Axios, according to video of the event.

But last month, many of Benioff’s onetime fans in San Francisco’s liberal community attacked him after he endorsed

SEE BENIOFF ON A20

Stiff-armed in Spain



MANU FERNANDEZ/AP

Cornerback Jonathan Jones, right, and the Commanders couldn’t handle wide receiver Malik Washington and the Dolphins in Madrid on Sunday, falling, 16-13, in overtime in the NFL’s first game in Spain. **Story, C1**

Off-label, GLP-1s are used to treat addiction

Some doctors prescribing weight-loss medication to reduce cravings for alcohol and illicit drugs

BY DAVID OVALLE

MIAMI — When Susan Akin first started injecting a coveted weight-loss drug early this year, the chaos in her brain quieted. The relentless cravings subsided — only they’d never been for food.

The medication instead dulled her urges for the cocaine and alcohol that caused her to plow her car into a tree, spiral into psychosis and wind up admitted to a high-end addiction treatment center in Delray Beach, Florida.

Doctors at Caron Treatment Centers tried a novel approach for the slender 41-year-old by prescribing her Zepbound, part of a blockbuster class of obesity and diabetes medications known as GLP-1s. Federal regulators have not approved the drugs for behav-

ioral health, but doctors are already prescribing them off-label, encouraged by studies suggesting that they could reshape addiction treatment.

Scientists caution that the research remains nascent. Health insurers do not cover the pricey drugs for that purpose. Addiction specialists say the medications might not be a cure but may work as a tool to quell addictive behaviors.

For Akin, the weekly shot helps her endure a world full of triggers. She can visit a gas station without wanting to buy beer or see sugar without dialing a cocaine dealer. The cravings linger but are muted, she said.

“I know when I’m due for my shot because I get a little antsy or irritable, or just kind of off,” Akin said. “But it has changed my life.”

SEE GLP-1 ON A2

Mystery of alleged Nazi tunnels has long polarized town in southern Brazil

BY TERRENCE MCCOY

IBIRUBÁ, BRAZIL — Looking up at the darkened edifice, the gumshoe thought he was on the cusp of his big break. For years, this house off the town square had fascinated and tormented him. He’d interviewed dozens of residents, pored over old newspaper

clippings and spent every spare cent in pursuit of what he believed was a secret, shameful history buried beneath it.

But Clóvis Messerschmidt had never been inside the house. Not until that night in 2022, the night before it was to be demolished. It was his final chance to bring back definitive proof of a story he had

staked his journalistic credibility on — that several prominent inhabitants of this ethnically German town in southern Brazil had been Nazi sympathizers, and that they’d hidden fugitives fleeing from Nazi hunters and the collapse of the Third Reich in a clandestine tunnel system.

Messerschmidt, 45, the pub-

lisher, editor and lead reporter of Enfoque, a local magazine with a circulation of 1,000, waited until well past midnight. Then he and two fellow sleuths made their move, the three men recalled in interviews — hopping the wall, climbing the porch and reaching for the front door. It had been left unlocked.

“I was super nervous,” recalled Fábio Loreno Bueno, who shared his friend’s obsession. “A lot of people didn’t want us to discover what was there.”

Messerschmidt led the way, taking a brazen step deeper into a saga that has consumed his life and divided his hometown. Since

SEE BRAZIL ON A13

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MAGA’s future Chris Buskirk, who helped put tech elites at the center of power in Washington, is working to equip the president’s movement to outlive him. **A8**

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